BUSINESS SYSTEMS

Before You Buy Another CRM, Find the Missing Quote

Use one account and one real job to decide what has to change.



Fran Herrera · Co-founder, Strategy & Operations
Updated November 14, 2026 · 5 min read

The owner of a commercial service firm sees a $240,000 quote in the pipeline. It shows as open. The rep says the customer accepted it last week. Operations has opened a job under the site address. Finance has a deposit against the parent company. At the sales meeting, the owner has to ask three people whether they're looking at the same job.

The team is preparing to see another CRM. The vendor is ready to show a pipeline with no duplicate records and a dashboard that updates as a deal moves. The firm needs to find out what happens when its own customer calls.

Before replacing a CRM, reproduce the problem with real records and identify where it begins. Separate the definition of an account or opportunity, the behavior the team needs, missing integrations, and limits of the platform. Ask each option to pass the same test using cases your company actually handles.

How do you distinguish a software limit from a record problem?

Trace how the quote was created, accepted, and turned into an operational job. Check which identifiers and statuses each team uses, what the current tool can support, and where a person still has to make a choice. Many apparent duplicate records reflect a distinction the company has yet to define.

QuickBooks gives a familiar example. A customer pays an invoice and the deposit appears in the bank feed. If someone adds it as new income instead of matching it to the existing payment, the books can show the same income twice. Intuit's guidance starts by checking the bank statement to find out whether the transaction happened once or twice. The distinction changes the fix. A duplicate in the books is a record problem. Two charges on the statement need to be investigated with the bank or processor. Intuit on diagnosing duplicate bank-feed entries

In the service firm, the parent is the party that pays, the site is the place that receives the work, and the opportunity belongs to a specific quote. Three records may be the right model. The team needs those records to point to the same job where relevant. An automatic merge by company name could erase the distinction between two locations. Start with how the business identifies each one.

Take the quote to finance and ask for the first record they saw. If they could see the quote ID and deliberately applied payment to the parent, ask how the job should inherit that reference. If they had no ID and matched payment by customer name alone, change the payment instructions and test a second location. If two systems already use the same ID but their statuses disagree, look at which event is supposed to update the pipeline and how a failed update becomes visible. The same Monday meeting can point to three different investments.

What should a CRM vendor demonstrate with your workflow?

Give the vendor a handful of redacted cases, including the ones that cause trouble. Require the demonstration to start where the data enters, show who does what, and end where the business verifies the result. Run the same script with your existing system after a small configuration test.

Test case	What the team should be able to see
One owner, two sites, two quotes	A rep can identify which site accepted which scope. Finance can identify the payer.
One quote is revised after a site visit	The current price is visible with the accepted version and a trace of earlier versions.
An accepted quote fails to create a job	The error reaches a named employee. A retry creates the job once.
The account rep is away	A colleague can pick up the customer's question from the record.

A system that can do this with your data and access rules may have earned a closer look. Ask what is native, what needs custom work, and who can maintain it. If your current system passes with a smaller change, you have a useful baseline for judging whether moving is worth it.

For the failed transfer, make it an explicit demonstration. Ask the vendor to turn off the connection, accept the quote and show what sales and operations each see. Then restore it and retry. Check that the opportunity, job and finance record still point to one accepted revision. If the vendor needs an engineer to clean up the sample afterward, ask who will do that when the same thing happens on a Tuesday with twenty jobs in flight.

When does a replacement make commercial sense?

Replace a CRM when an important, demonstrated requirement remains unmet and another option can meet it at a cost and disruption the business can justify. Include migration, duplicate cleanup, retraining, integrations, parallel operation where needed, and support after launch.

Use a **CRM Decision Record** for the missing quote. Record the symptom, the current cause you can demonstrate, the test cases, and the results for keeping, configuring, integrating and replacing the tool. If a unique quote ID can cross from accepted quote to job to invoice, test that first. If the current system cannot expose the information you need or enforce an essential access boundary, compare alternatives that can show they do it with your cases.

Check the cost after the demo. A cheaper seat price may require someone to maintain a connector or reconcile records each month. An expensive migration may be justified if it removes a recurring failure that the current setup cannot address. Name who owns those trade-offs and what evidence will decide.

Three things to bring to the vendor meeting.

- A real account that breaks in a way the business cares about.
- A test from first entry through acceptance, delivery, or invoicing.
- A view of the cost and responsibility after the software goes live.

At next Monday's sales meeting, the owner should be able to open the accepted quote and see which job and deposit it led to. Ask the demo to show that meeting.

Frequently asked questions

Does low CRM adoption justify a switch?

Find out why people leave it. It may be slower than their current method, omit a useful field, or require duplicate entry. Test a change on the actual work before deciding whether the platform is the limit.

Should every old record be migrated?

Decide which history people need to keep using and which material belongs in a searchable archive. Test access and reconciliation for important records before switching.

What should you verify first after migration?

Pick an active customer with an open quote and a recent order. Check the links, permissions, and next actions against the source records, then repeat with known edge cases.

The service firm and quote value are illustrative. The accounting example comes from Intuit's public documentation.